> whose patriotic labours … enterprise in the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company have brought to the front on … and Tuticorin port—the sole monopoly of [white-] skinned men hitherto. I stay here contributing articles to newspapers and you will be glad to learn I am doing all in my power to further our swadeshi cause. […] I am the correspondent to the *Bengalee*, to which I have addressed a stirring letter on your enterprise of Swadeshi Steam Navigation. I have also written to *Bande Mataram*. I shall be happy to learn from you if my stay here can in anyway be usefully spent on behalf of your devoted cause in the way of moving public men to patronise our shares. I addressed several meetings of students in the premises of literary associations […] I am now preaching the subject of Swadeshism […] is the test to genuine patriotism […]

These letters are revealing. By early 1907, VOC was a star whose fame had spread far and wide among patriots. In the popular mind he was the sole architect of the company—its founder and its executor. His control of the day-to-day affairs of SSNCo, even from distant Bombay, is clear. From afar, he was hiring employees, instructing the company to advance money, etc.

Thambusami Pillai's job description seems to have not involved direct company administrative work but propaganda through the press. That he proved to be a turncoat is a different matter.[17] It also bears testimony to BI's efforts to wean away uncommitted and wavering employees from SSNCo. In this particular case, Thambusami Pillai resigned after barely five weeks. Instead of the Rs 30 per month that SSNCo paid him, he now got Rs 35—barely five silvers more.[18] The details of this exceptional case throw light on the nature of recruitment: the kind of people who were hired; the paperwork involved despite the informal process of recruitment; the barely existing line dividing political work and shipping business; VOC's control of the company even from afar; and the price that VOC and his company paid for trusting an undependable person.

VOC's powers did not please some potentates in the company, causing difficulties. One of SSNCo's legal advisers, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar denied that Gurunathaiyar was ever in the employ of the company: 'It might be that Chidambaram Pillai has several friends for which the company cannot be responsible.'[19] It was a sticking point with the management that it was VOC's writ that mattered with the staff. The displeasure of a section of the company management with VOC extracted a heavy price, as we shall see.